bowl from him and polished off the lot without breaking sweat – and even asked for some more! Frankly, no one else could have eaten even half a spoonful.

A final to remember

When we returned to the hotel after the last pool game, I was very tired and yet I just couldn't get to sleep. I eventually dropped off well after 2 a.m. With just a day before the final, this didn't bode well. In the extreme heat I had lost a lot of fluid and I needed time to get myself rehydrated and allow my body and mind to recover.

When I got up in the morning my body was stiff. My back was tight and I was even finding it difficult to walk to the bathroom. The stiffness was partly a result of the dehydration and the first thing I did was drink a lot of water. There have been a few occasions in my career when I have had difficulties standing up straight in the mornings. Sometimes I have really had to push myself to get off the bed and in extreme situations the physio and the masseur have had to give me a helping hand. Of course, I didn't mind the stiffness so much if I had scored a hundred or played a match-winning knock the day before. In that case, it was a happy feeling and a reminder of the effort I had put in! However, if the stiffness was caused by fielding for two long days, I would resent it immensely. So at Sharjah I had no reason to complain about the pain – it was a very small price to pay.

At lunchtime, I met Mark Mascarenhas for a meal at his hotel. Ravi Shastri, Shane Warne and Richie Benaud, former Australian captain and one of the greatest cricketers to have played the game, were also present and I had a brief non-cricketing chat with them all before returning to the hotel. I wasn't particularly concerned about the physical aspect of the recovery, as I was confident of digging into my reserves. I was more concerned with the mental recovery after such a high-intensity encounter.

In the evening, I had an interesting conversation with Mark. It was the Coca-Cola Cup and I was informed that, as sponsors, Coca-Cola wanted to announce a reward for me for the innings I had played the night before. They wanted to give me £25,000, which was a substantial sum of money. When Mark asked me what I'd do with it, I said that I would share it with my team-mates. It was our practice to share rewards among